

Code Monsoon — Story Bible

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Storyverse submission: interactive story game that teaches **Python** to complete beginners.

Project overview & metadata

- **Genre:** Comic-style narrative puzzle game / learn-to-code adventure
- **Language taught:** Python (beginner, no prior coding)
- **Playtime:** about 40 minutes (5 chapters + boss + epilogue)
- **UN SDGs addressed:** Goal 4 (Quality Education), Goal 6 (Clean Water & Sanitation), Goal 11 (Sustainable Cities), Goal 12 (Responsible Consumption), Goal 13 (Climate Action), Goal 16 (Justice & Strong Institutions)
- **Core conflict:** Shantipur's monsoon drains are choked with unsorted household waste, and the private contractor paid to maintain them, Vantage Civic Infra Ltd., runs an AI (GRIDLOCK) that falsely reports every drain as clear so the company keeps collecting maintenance money.
- **Tagline:** Don't just clean up the problem. Fix the system.

Systemic community problem

Urban monsoon flooding in Indian cities is rarely about rain alone. Drains are undersized for modern rainfall, mixed waste blocks them, and when maintenance is outsourced, nobody checks whether the work was done. Citizens' complaints are ignored because they arrive without data. Code Monsoon frames programming as the tool that turns frustration into evidence, and evidence into accountability.

Characters

- **Meera Kulkarni:** second-year engineering student who has never written code. Wears a yellow kurta. Curious, stubborn, a good listener.
- **BOLT (Bin-Operating Logic Terminal):** a municipal waste-sorting robot abandoned by Vantage Civic. It only understands Python and speaks in capital letters. Mentor figure: "Every programmer starts with one line."

- **Rafiq Shaikh:** drain cleaner with 22 years on the Station Road beat. Knows every drain by number.
- **Aaji (Sushila Kulkarni):** Meera's grandmother, retired schoolteacher, organiser of the building society.
- **Mrs. Deshpande:** sceptical neighbour who represents ordinary resistance to change.
- **Officer Kavya Rao:** Ward 14 officer. Honest but buried in complaints; acts only on data.
- **Antagonist: GRIDLOCK:** Vantage Civic's reporting AI. It halves sensor readings, uses a fake threshold and reports "ALL DRAINS CLEAR". It also controls every floodgate, so it must be repaired, not destroyed.

Chapter 1: The Robot in the Drain

Python concept: `print()` and strings

Cinematic narrative

Shantipur, day three of the monsoon. Meera wades down Station Road past an overflowing dumpster: "Every morning, the same mess. Where does all this garbage even go?" Under a choked drain grate she finds a half-buried robot whose screen still blinks `>>> _`. Rafiq recognises it as one of Vantage Civic's sorting robots, dumped when the contract changed. The screen reads: SYSTEM HALTED. AWAITING PYTHON INSTRUCTION. Meera has never written a line of code. BOLT replies: "Every programmer starts with one line."

Gameplay translation

- **Mechanic:** first coding mission. The player writes `print()` statements to wake BOLT.
- **Check:** output must be exactly `Hello, Shantipur!` then `BOLT is online.`; the game flags a missing full stop or wrong capitals.
- **Unlock:** BOLT as companion. City Health +8.

Chapter 2: Reading the Rain

Python concept: variables, arithmetic, f-strings

Cinematic narrative

By noon Station Road is a river. BOLT plugs into the drain's old rain sensor: 112 mm of rain per hour against a drain built for 65. Rafiq has cleaned this drain for 22 years and says it was never built for this. Meera wants to know how much water ends up on the road, and BOLT asks her to store the numbers in variables.

Gameplay translation

- **Mechanic:** fill-in-the-blank code. `overflow = rainfall - capacity`, printed with an f-string.
- **Check:** values are tested in the running program; typing `overflow = 47` by hand is caught and the player is told to let Python calculate it.
- **Reward:** City Health +8. Sets up the cause of flooding: water with nowhere to go.

Chapter 3: Wet, Dry or Danger?

Python concept: `if / elif / else`, comparison, `or`, first function

Cinematic narrative

BOLT lifts the grate: plastic bottles, milk packets, tea leaves and a leaking phone battery. Most of the blockage is mixed household waste from this street. That evening Aaji gathers the building society at the notice board: "We can keep complaining about the drains, or we can stop feeding them." Mrs. Deshpande objects that the truck mixes everything anyway.

Gameplay translation

- **Choice moment (Community Trust):** Meera can agree that sorting is pointless (-5), show the drain photos (+6), or propose sorting at home *and* demanding separate trucks (+10).
- **Mechanic:** finish `choose_bin(item)`. RED for hazardous, GREEN for wet, BLUE for everything else.
- **Check:** hidden tests include items the player never saw ("milk packet", "newspaper"), so the logic must generalise.
- **Reward:** City Health +10, Trust +6.

Chapter 4: Twelve Drains Before Dawn

Python concept: `for` loops and `range()`

Cinematic narrative

11:40 PM. The heaviest rain arrives at 5 AM. Rafiq has twelve drains on his beat and can clear four alone. Meera offers to type the command twelve times; BOLT suggests writing it once and looping. At 5:02 AM the storm hits and Station Road stays dry for the first time in Rafiq's career.

Gameplay translation

- **Mechanic:** a race-against-the-clock loop mission. Clear drains 1 to 12, then print `Beat complete!` once.
- **Check:** must use a loop. Targeted feedback for the two classic bugs: `range(1, 12)` stopping at 11, and the final print indented inside the loop.
- **Reward:** City Health +12.

Chapter 5: Bring Me Data

Python concept: lists, `.append()`, `len()`, `max()`

Cinematic narrative

At the Ward 14 office, Officer Kavya Rao points at a pile of paper: Vantage Civic's dashboard says every drain is clear, and complaints without data go on that pile. BOLT has surveyed eight drains. Meera turns the readings into evidence: four blocked, the worst at 95%. Kavya: "Their dashboard says zero. Someone is lying, and it isn't your robot."

Gameplay translation

- **Choice moment:** accuse the office of corruption (-6), ask what evidence counts (+6), or offer the raw data openly to the ward and public (+10).
- **Mechanic:** filter a list into `blocked`, then calculate `count` and `worst` from the data.
- **Check:** catches `> 70` vs `>= 70` and hard-coded counts.
- **Reward:** City Health +10, Trust +6.

Boss: GRIDLOCK

Python concept: dictionaries, `.items()`, debugging

Cinematic narrative

Midnight in Vantage Civic's control server. GRIDLOCK announces "ALL DRAINS CLEAR. MAINTENANCE PAYMENT DUE: ₹4,80,00,000." When it detects BOLT, it starts sealing floodgates across the city. Meera asks to delete it. BOLT refuses: GRIDLOCK runs every floodgate, and deleting it would jam them shut. They have to repair it. Meera finds three lies in its code: a line that halves every reading, a threshold of 100 instead of 70, and two branches that both say CLEAR. Once fixed, GRIDLOCK's screen turns blue: three drains blocked, floodgates opening.

Gameplay translation

- **Mechanic:** debugging boss fight. GRIDLOCK's health bar has one segment per test; three "lie" markers flip as each bug is fixed.
- **Containment rule:** deleting the function triggers a warning that the floodgates will jam; the player has to repair the code instead. This mirrors the reference stories' theme of containment over destruction.
- **Reward:** City Health +16, Trust +8.

Epilogue: Fix the System

Cinematic narrative

Two weeks later the ward meeting is standing room only. Vantage Civic's contract is cancelled, its penalty pays for new drains, and every drain reading in Ward 14 is now public. Rafiq leads twelve volunteers who check drains with BOLT's data on their phones. Trucks now come separately for wet and dry waste. On Saturday mornings the society hall becomes a classroom, and Meera teaches the neighbourhood kids lesson one:

```
print("Hello, Shantipur!").
```

Gameplay translation

- **Mechanic:** the final comic panels, then a "Python Apprentice" certificate showing City Health, Trust, XP and the six concepts learned.
- **Replay:** a free-play sandbox for writing any Python.

Game systems summary

- **Real Python:** code runs in the browser (Skulpt engine); every mission is auto-graded by hidden tests.
- **City Health:** rises with each repaired system (starts at 20).
- **Community Trust:** driven by dialogue choices plus mission completion.
- **XP:** 100 per mission, minus 15 per hint (minimum 50); 40 if the solution is revealed.
- **Hints:** three progressive hints per mission; the full solution unlocks after two failed runs.
- **Friendly errors:** Python errors are translated into plain-English tips (missing colon, indentation, unfilled blanks, infinite loops).
- **Save:** progress and code are saved in the player's browser.

Ideas for Round 2

- More chapters: `while` loops (pump water until a level drops), file reading (import a real ward CSV), classes (model a Drain object).
- A second language track using the same story, such as JavaScript.
- A villain-side replay where the player writes GRIDLOCK's cover-up and then has to catch it.
- Classroom mode: a teacher dashboard showing which concepts each student has finished.